

it is one of the functions of art—by no means the only one, but one nevertheless—to provoke in a society the arguments by which that society comes to understand itself better, and by which, perhaps, it progresses. (The Husain case suggests, less optimistically, that such arguments can also lead to regression, to a society deciding to be less than it was before.)

Art is not the enemy of the people. It is the work which, for future generations, will tell the story of what our time was like. The artist is the people's ambassador to the future.

Why it is so easy to mobilise public opinion against artists, so easy for the accusation of their alleged "provocations" to become the point rather than the violent reaction to their work? A painting is an object in a space. If you don't like the sound of it, you don't have to look at it. The notion that it "provokes" merely by existing somewhere on earth is irrational, yet it is an unreason many people see as reasonable. A book you don't like doesn't have to be purchased or opened—this is why we have books by many different authors in our bookstores—or, if opened, it can be shut, at which point it presumably loses its ability to offend. Yet, once again, the very existence of an unread book is seen as a sufficient provocation, causing "injury" and therefore becoming responsible for whatever injuries may subsequently be inflicted by the supposedly injured parties. The same, it seems, can be true of an unseen film or an unheard song.

A part of the answer, I believe is that the arts are soft targets. They have no troops, and they are vulnerable. Paintings can be destroyed, books can be burned, libraries can be devastated, film theatres can be menaced. That's pretty obvious. A more difficult part of the answer, however, may be that in India—by no means only in India, but also in India—people suspect artists. They are thought of as some sort of self-justifying elite—which is an extraordinary misconception, in the light of how difficult, provisional, often ill-paid and unrecognised a life dedicated to the arts can be.

Most writers, painters, musicians, actors struggle. Even those who become well known have usually paid their dues with long years of penury and hardship.

I am asking, in short, for a better understanding of what art is, and a greater respect for the people who make it. And central to that understanding is the principle that art seeks to open the universe, and it does so according to the vision of each individual artist; and if it is not cherished, not given the space in which such visions can flower, then it will die, and with it will perish the collective imagination of the human race. And it will inevitably be the case that individual works of art will step on the toes of this or that group, will shock and challenge and offend some of us. That is the price an open society pays for its openness, and we must simply learn to deal with it, to turn away from what we dislike towards the things we love.

If India goes down the road of communalised culture, it will, make no mistake, alienate many of those in the outside world who currently admire it. If this becomes a culture of religious intolerance, well, there are many such countries in the world, and were India to fall into that group, it would lose its unique standing in the international community. Let us not become another closed world, another China, another Iran, another Pakistan. Let our universe remain open, and let us strive to open it further.

In closing, I would like to emphasise once again that I say what I have said not in the name of some alien, incompatible, "Western" idea of liberty, but in the name of the ancient and astonishingly liberal and sophisticated culture which it is our privilege to share.

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## DISCUSSION

**Q. Would you say that the British government acted well when they gave you protection when the *fatwa* was issued against you?**

A. The British government took the position that if a foreign power is trying to execute one of its citizens, they should try and make sure it doesn't happen. And the fact they did is a further example of principled nature. So yes, of course, I was very grateful of them. Other governments should take lead from this and make sure that the people attacked by whatever threat should

be defended, rather than blamed for it.

**Q. How did you handle intolerance and how did it affect your work?**

A. I discovered that I am a very obstinate person and my reaction to people who are trying to shut me up is to talk louder. I think the best answer you could give to somebody trying to silence your voice is to try and speak with greater firmness. If somebody is trying to suppress your work, try and write a better book. The best answer of the artist is always in the

art. And yes, I have been obliged to become this kind of person who stands at places like this and makes speeches like this. But actually in my view, the best work I have ever done is the work I do privately in my room by myself.

**Q. Do you self-censor yourself?**

A. Do I sound like it? I believe very passionately in the idea of literature as a vocation, as a calling, and it seems to me that my respect for it is too great to wish to abuse it in that way. If I felt unable to write freely and fully, I would prefer to be

silent. It seems to me there are enough books in the world. If all of us professional writers were to stop writing today, there would be still too many books in the world. And in our lifetimes, none of us would be able to read all great works there are to read. So if we are going to have the nerve to add to that mountain, then it has to be truthful work. It has to be something that comes from the deepest vision of your world and it has to try and express that. And if it doesn't do that, it would be best to save the trees.